The University City Compass

18 student cities · rated out of 10 against the top 10 priorities for university students

The goal: to graduate capable, thoughtful, and adaptable, ready not just for a job but for life, while lifting others up along the way.

The 10 criteria

Criterion	What it means
Quality education	Strong teaching, relevant and up-to-date courses, and respected degrees that equip students for a changing world.
Affordability	Manageable tuition and living costs, plus scholarships and financial aid.
Safety and convenience	Secure housing, reliable transport, accessible healthcare, and everyday services within easy reach.
Personal growth	Building confidence, discipline, and resilience, along with healthy relationships and lasting friendships.
Broader horizons	Meeting new people, exploring cultures, and exchanging ideas with open-minded peers who see the world differently.
Experience and wisdom	Gaining maturity from challenges, mistakes, responsibility, and everyday life.
Independence and flexibility	Managing money, solving problems, and thriving in unfamiliar situations.
Career readiness	Hands-on exposure through projects, research, internships, and apprenticeships, while building a professional network with employers.
Collaboration and community	Sharing expertise, working toward common goals, and combining strengths so everyone achieves more.
Lifelong opportunity	Expanding possibilities with knowledge, skills, continuous learning, and meaningful contribution.

How the scores work

Each city gets a score from 1 to 10 on each criterion: **10 = outstanding**, **8 = strong**, **6 = adequate**, **4 = limited**, **2 = weak**. Odd numbers sit in between.

Starting point: the scores in the original report (out of 5) were doubled.

Then re-checked against your criteria. Your wording adds things the old report did not stress: scholarships and financial aid, housing and healthcare, friendships and resilience, learning from everyday challenges, managing in unfamiliar situations, and employer networks. Where the report's own notes show a city is clearly stronger or weaker on these, the score moved by 1 point. **12 scores changed**; they are listed on the next page and highlighted in each city table.

No new research was done. Changes use only facts already in the report. Scores are indicative judgements, not measurements. There is no overall ranking, total or average.

Score matrix (out of 10)

Cities in the original order. Highlighted cells changed after checking against your criteria.

City	Edu	Aff	Saf	Gro	Hor	Wis	Ind	Car	Com	Opp
Kuala Lumpur	10	10	8	8	10	8	8	10	10	10
Istanbul	10	**7**	6	10	10	**9**	**9**	8	8	8
Riyadh	8	10	10	6	6	6	6	10	6	8
Dhahran / Dammam	10	10	10	6	6	**7**	6	10	8	8
Ankara	10	8	8	8	8	8	8	**9**	8	8
Doha	8	8	10	8	8	6	8	8	8	8
Abu Dhabi	8	8	10	8	8	6	8	8	8	8
Penang	8	10	8	8	8	8	8	8	8	8
Cairo	8	10	6	**9**	8	10	**9**	6	10	6
Astana	8	**9**	8	6	6	6	8	8	6	8
Almaty	8	10	8	8	8	8	8	6	8	6
Dubai	6	4	10	8	10	6	8	10	8	8
Izmir	8	10	8	8	8	8	8	6	8	6
Amman	8	8	8	**9**	8	8	8	6	10	8
Baku	6	10	8	6	6	6	**7**	6	6	6
Alexandria	6	10	6	8	6	8	8	6	8	6
Tashkent	6	10	8	**7**	6	6	**7**	6	6	6
Rabat	6	10	8	8	8	8	8	6	8	8

***Edu** = Quality education · **Aff** = Affordability · **Saf** = Safety and convenience · **Gro** = Personal growth · **Hor** = Broader horizons · **Wis** = Experience and wisdom · **Ind** = Independence and flexibility · **Car** = Career readiness · **Com** = Collaboration and community · **Opp** = Lifelong opportunity*

What changed and why

City	Criterion	Before	Now	Why
Istanbul	Affordability	6	**7**	Scholarships now count, and private universities offer generous ones.
Istanbul	Experience and wisdom	8	**9**	A demanding megacity gives daily challenges that build maturity.
Istanbul	Independence and flexibility	8	**9**	Getting around the megacity builds self-reliance quickly.
Dhahran / Dammam	Experience and wisdom	8	**7**	The new wording is about life challenges; campus life here is sheltered.
Ankara	Career readiness	8	**9**	Employers recruit on campus and technoparks give hands-on work (employer network now counts).
Cairo	Personal growth	8	**9**	Resilience is learned fast, with a huge pool of lifelong friends.
Cairo	Independence and flexibility	8	**9**	Students learn problem solving, negotiation and improvisation.
Astana	Affordability	8	**9**	State grants often cover tuition plus a stipend (financial aid now counts).
Amman	Personal growth	8	**9**	Lasting friendships across the whole Arab region now count.
Baku	Independence and flexibility	6	**7**	Azerbaijani or Russian needed daily: real practice in unfamiliar situations.
Tashkent	Personal growth	6	**7**	Daily language immersion builds resilience and character.
Tashkent	Independence and flexibility	6	**7**	Uzbek or Russian needed daily: real practice in unfamiliar situations.

City profiles

Kuala Lumpur, Malaysia

Universities: Universiti Malaya (UM)

Southeast Asia's most complete student package: a world top-60 university, English-medium teaching, and one of the lowest costs of any ranked university city.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**10 / 10**	UM is 58th in QS WUR 2026 and 56th in 2027. Malaysia's flagship, with top-100 subjects across engineering, computer science and business. [1][2]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Public tuition is a few thousand USD per year; comfortable student life on roughly USD 500–800 a month.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Generally safe with good metro links; routine big-city caution against petty theft.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Active campus clubs, leadership programmes and a lively student-city scene.
Broader horizons	**10 / 10**	Malay, Chinese and Indian cultures meet in one English-speaking, Muslim-majority metropolis.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	ASEAN's business hub gives real industry exposure alongside study.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Easy independent living, friendly student visas, halal food everywhere.
Career readiness	**10 / 10**	Strong regional job market in finance, tech and energy; degrees well recognised across Asia.
Collaboration and community	**10 / 10**	Tens of thousands of international students; Malaysia is a top global study destination.
Lifelong opportunity	**10 / 10**	Post-study work options and alumni networks spanning ASEAN and the wider Muslim world.

Istanbul, Türkiye

Universities: Istanbul Technical University · Boğaziçi University · Istanbul University · Koç University · Sabancı University

Five world-ranked universities in a city that is itself an education: Europe and Asia in one skyline.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**10 / 10**	ITU (298th), Boğaziçi (371), Koç (323) and Sabancı (404) all sit in the QS WUR 2026 top tier; ITU is 91st worldwide for Engineering & Technology. [1]
Affordability	**7 / 10** was 6	Public tuition is low, but inflation has raised living costs; private universities are costly without their generous scholarships. **Change:** Scholarships now count, and private universities offer generous ones.
Safety and convenience	**6 / 10**	A vast, thrilling but demanding megacity: traffic, crowding and economic volatility require adjustment.
Personal growth	**10 / 10**	Unmatched cultural life: arts, debate, volunteering and student societies in a city of 16 million.
Broader horizons	**10 / 10**	A living crossroads of civilisations; few cities widen a student's worldview faster.
Experience and wisdom	**9 / 10** was 8	Centuries of scholarship plus a large modern industry base to learn from. **Change:** A demanding megacity gives daily challenges that build maturity.
Independence and flexibility	**9 / 10** was 8	Navigating the megacity builds self-reliance quickly; some Turkish helps daily life. **Change:** Getting around the megacity builds self-reliance quickly.
Career readiness	**8 / 10**	Türkiye's largest economy: deep internship pools in engineering, finance, media and trade.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Huge student communities and strong Erasmus and exchange links with Europe.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Powerful alumni networks across Türkiye, Europe and the Middle East.

Riyadh, Saudi Arabia

Universities: King Saud University (KSU) · Princess Nourah bint Abdulrahman University (PNU)

The Kingdom's academic capital, riding the Vision 2030 wave of investment in education and research.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	KSU ranks 143rd in QS WUR 2026 and 4th in the QS Arab Region 2026; PNU is the world's largest women's university. [1][3]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Public university education is tuition-free, often with a monthly student stipend.
Safety and convenience	**10 / 10**	Very low crime, orderly streets and a modernising metro system.
Personal growth	**6 / 10**	Conservative social rules are easing fast, but leisure options remain narrower than in Dubai or Doha.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	More local in character than the coastal Gulf hubs: deep Saudi culture, fewer foreign residents.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	A serious, structured study environment with growing research exposure.
Independence and flexibility	**6 / 10**	Campus life is organised and supportive, though less free-form than Western cities.
Career readiness	**10 / 10**	Vision 2030 megaprojects, Aramco and the banking sector create exceptional graduate demand.
Collaboration and community	**6 / 10**	Gender-segregated campuses shape a different, though close-knit, community experience.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Strong ladder into Gulf careers, government programmes and scholarships abroad.

Dhahran / Dammam, Saudi Arabia

Universities: King Fahd University of Petroleum & Minerals (KFUPM)

A focused science-and-engineering powerhouse beside the world's energy capital.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**10 / 10**	KFUPM is 67th in QS WUR 2026 and 1st in the QS Arab Region 2026, elite in petroleum, chemical and electrical engineering. [1][3]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Admission typically comes with full scholarships, housing and stipends.
Safety and convenience	**10 / 10**	A calm, very safe planned city anchored by the university and Aramco.
Personal growth	**6 / 10**	Quiet, studious atmosphere; fewer diversions than Jeddah or Riyadh.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	International faculty and industry visitors, though the student mix is less cosmopolitan.
Experience and wisdom	**7 / 10** was 8	Daily proximity to the energy industry is an education in itself. **Change:** The new wording is about life challenges; campus life here is sheltered.
Independence and flexibility	**6 / 10**	Campus-centred living: comfortable but sheltered.
Career readiness	**10 / 10**	A near-direct pipeline into Aramco, SABIC and the Gulf energy sector.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Small, tight-knit campus community with strong cohort spirit.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Alumni lead the region's energy, engineering and technology sectors.

Ankara, Türkiye

Universities: Middle East Technical University (METU) · Bilkent University

Türkiye's top public and private universities in a calm, purpose-built student capital.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**10 / 10**	METU is 269th and Bilkent 415th in QS WUR 2026, the country's premier public and private institutions. [1]
Affordability	**8 / 10**	Public fees are minimal and living costs sit well below Istanbul's.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Orderly, compact and used to students; calmer than the big coastal cities.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Strong campus culture: METU's societies and spring festivals are legendary.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	English-medium teaching at both flagships, with wide exchange networks.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	The seat of government, embassies and think-tanks offers civic and policy exposure.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	A manageable city where students quickly learn to stand on their own feet.
Career readiness	**9 / 10** was 8	Technoparks and the defence, aerospace and software sectors recruit heavily on campus. **Change:** Employers recruit on campus and technoparks give hands-on work (employer network now counts).
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Large, engaged student population with a collaborative academic culture.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Alumni dominate Turkish engineering, academia and public life.

Doha, Qatar

Universities: Qatar University · Education City (Georgetown, Northwestern, Carnegie Mellon, Weill Cornell Medicine and more)

One city hosting a whole district of world-class branch campuses alongside the national university.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	Qatar University is 112th in QS WUR 2026 and 2nd in the Arab region; Education City brings top US campuses to one district. [1][3]
Affordability	**8 / 10**	Qatar Foundation and QU scholarships are generous; daily costs are high but often covered.
Safety and convenience	**10 / 10**	Routinely ranked among the world's safest cities, with a clean, modern metro.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Excellent facilities, sports and cultural institutions such as the Museum of Islamic Art.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	An expat-majority, World Cup-tested city with a genuinely global outlook.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Smaller local scene; the deepest experience comes through campus and internships.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Compact and easy to navigate: independent living comes naturally here.
Career readiness	**8 / 10**	Energy, finance, aviation and sports industries offer premium internships.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Education City's inter-campus life lets students mix across universities.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Strong routes into Gulf employers and the branch campuses' home institutions.

Abu Dhabi, United Arab Emirates

Universities: Khalifa University · NYU Abu Dhabi

The UAE capital pairs a rising research university with one of the world's most selective liberal-arts colleges.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	Khalifa University is 177th in QS WUR 2026 and 3rd in the Arab region; NYU Abu Dhabi admits single-digit percentages of applicants. [1][3]
Affordability	**8 / 10**	NYU Abu Dhabi meets full demonstrated need; Khalifa offers scholarships, but the city itself is expensive.
Safety and convenience	**10 / 10**	Regularly listed among the safest cities on earth; excellent infrastructure.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	High-quality sports, arts and beach life balanced with study.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	A global hub where classmates and colleagues come from everywhere.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Purpose-built and polished; less organic street life than older cities.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Modern, well-organised city: independence is easy to practise.
Career readiness	**8 / 10**	Energy, aerospace, AI and sovereign-fund employers sit on the doorstep.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	NYU Abu Dhabi's student body is famously international; Khalifa's cohort is research-driven.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Degrees open doors across the Gulf and, via NYU, worldwide.

Penang, Malaysia

Universities: Universiti Sains Malaysia (USM)

A top-150 research university on a heritage island of street food, temples and tech factories.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	USM is joint 128th in QS WUR 2027 and holds Malaysia's APEX research status. [2]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Among the cheapest quality study destinations anywhere: low fees, low rents, inexpensive food.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	A relaxed island with low crime and easy buses and ride-hailing.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	George Town's arts scene, festivals and outdoors give a rounded student life.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	A UNESCO-listed melting pot of Malay, Chinese, Indian and Peranakan cultures.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	Living in a working heritage port teaches lessons no classroom can.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Compact, friendly and English-speaking: an ideal first step abroad.
Career readiness	**8 / 10**	Penang's electronics cluster ("Silicon Valley of the East") offers serious engineering internships.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Warm campus community with students from across Asia, Africa and the Middle East.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	A respected springboard into Malaysian, Singaporean and regional careers.

Cairo, Egypt

Universities: Cairo University · Ain Shams University

Venerable mass universities at the heart of the Arab world's cultural capital.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	Cairo University stands 363rd in QS WUR 2027, Egypt's flagship, with medicine and engineering of long renown. [2]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Public tuition is symbolic and living costs are among the lowest of any major city.
Safety and convenience	**6 / 10**	A chaotic, intense megacity; safe in most districts but demanding on newcomers.
Personal growth	**9 / 10** was 8	Debate, theatre, journalism and activism have shaped generations of Arab leaders. **Change:** Resilience is learned fast, with a huge pool of lifelong friends.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	The cultural heart of the Arab world: media, literature and history on every corner.
Experience and wisdom	**10 / 10**	Five millennia of civilisation outside the lecture hall; wisdom comes with the address.
Independence and flexibility	**9 / 10** was 8	Students learn resilience, negotiation and improvisation very quickly. **Change:** Students learn problem solving, negotiation and improvisation.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	The domestic job market is tight and salaries low; the degree outperforms the local economy.
Collaboration and community	**10 / 10**	Hundreds of thousands of students: an unrivalled pool of peers and lifelong friends.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	A respected name across the Arab world, though many graduates seek work abroad.

Astana, Kazakhstan

Universities: Nazarbayev University · Astana Medical University

A young, ambitious capital whose flagship university was built with world-class partners.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	Nazarbayev University was founded with partners such as Cambridge and Duke; it is 831st in the U.S. News Best Global Universities table and climbing fast. [4]
Affordability	**9 / 10** was 8	State grants commonly cover tuition plus a stipend; living costs are moderate. **Change:** State grants often cover tuition plus a stipend (financial aid now counts).
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	A planned, low-crime capital, though winters are fiercely cold.
Personal growth	**6 / 10**	Small-city calm; the social scene centres on the campus.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	A young city still forming its identity; fewer established cultural institutions.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Modern curricula and research internships compensate for the shorter history.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	English-medium NU life pushes students toward self-direction and global habits.
Career readiness	**8 / 10**	The government, sovereign institutions and a growing tech scene hire NU graduates first.
Collaboration and community	**6 / 10**	Close-knit cohorts on a modern campus, but a smaller international community.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	NU alumni are fast-tracked into Kazakhstan's ministries, companies and PhD programmes abroad.

Almaty, Kazakhstan

Universities: Al-Farabi Kazakh National University (KazNU) · Kazakh National Medical University

Central Asia's leading university in its most cosmopolitan and liveable city.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	KazNU is 167th in QS WUR 2026 (177th in 2027), the number one university in Central Asia. [1][2]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Low tuition, cheap transport and some of the region's most affordable student living.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Relaxed, green and student-friendly, with mountains at the edge of town.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Cafés, hiking, skiing and an active student scene shape a balanced life.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	Kazakh, Russian and international cultures meet in the region's most open city.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	A Soviet-era scientific tradition renewed with international partnerships.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Easy to live independently; Russian or Kazakh helps outside campus.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	The regional business hub, though graduate salaries remain modest.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Large, sociable student community with growing exchange programmes.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	A strong name within Central Asia; global recognition still developing.

Dubai, United Arab Emirates

Universities: Mohammed Bin Rashid University (MBRU) · Dubai Medical College · international branch campuses

A global city of branch campuses where the classroom meets the marketplace.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**6 / 10**	Branch campuses inherit their home universities' names, but local quality varies; check the parent institution's standing. [1]
Affordability	**4 / 10**	The most expensive option on this list: high tuition and high rents, with scholarships only partial.
Safety and convenience	**10 / 10**	Exceptionally safe, with world-class transport, healthcare and services.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Endless events, sports and networking; self-discipline is needed amid the distractions.
Broader horizons	**10 / 10**	Over 200 nationalities in one city: a daily lesson in global citizenship.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Dazzling but young; depth comes from people rather than institutions.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Independent living is straightforward, if the budget allows.
Career readiness	**10 / 10**	Unmatched internship access in trade, aviation, hospitality, media and finance.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	A highly international student body, though many commute and community can feel transient.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	A Dubai degree plus work experience is a recognised springboard across the Gulf and beyond.

Izmir, Türkiye

Universities: Izmir Institute of Technology (IZTECH) · Ege University

A liberal Aegean student city with a strong technical institute and a giant public university.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	IZTECH teaches in English and punches above its weight in science and engineering; Ege is one of Türkiye's oldest and largest universities. [1]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Low public fees and some of the cheapest student living in the country.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Safe, seaside and famously easy-going.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Beaches, festivals and a youthful, open atmosphere.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	Aegean history and a tolerant, outward-looking local culture.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	Archaeology, agriculture and shipping make the region an open-air classroom.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	A gentle place to learn independence: friendly and manageable.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	A smaller regional economy; many graduates target Istanbul, Ankara or abroad.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Tight student communities around the campus districts.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	Respected within Türkiye; international name recognition is modest.

Amman, Jordan

Universities: University of Jordan (UJ) · Jordan University of Science and Technology (JUST)

The Levant's safest and most welcoming student hub, drawing youth from across the Arab world.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**8 / 10**	UJ is 10th in the QS Arab Region Rankings 2026; JUST is respected across the region for engineering, medicine and pharmacy. [3]
Affordability	**8 / 10**	Moderate fees and affordable living, though Amman is pricier than Jordan's other cities.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	One of the region's safest capitals; easy buses and walkable student districts.
Personal growth	**9 / 10** was 8	NGOs, startups and refugee-response programmes offer meaningful volunteer growth. **Change:** Lasting friendships across the whole Arab region now count.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	A crossroads of Levantine, Gulf and international students and ideas.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	Jerash, Petra and the Dead Sea turn weekends into history lessons.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	A gentle landing for a first time abroad; Arabic immersion comes naturally.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	High youth unemployment at home pushes graduates toward the Gulf.
Collaboration and community	**10 / 10**	A famously pan-Arab campus mix: friendships span the whole region.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	A proven pipeline into Gulf employers, UN agencies and postgraduate study abroad.

Baku, Azerbaijan

Universities: Baku State University · Azerbaijan Medical University

A Caspian oil capital modernising its universities along European lines.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**6 / 10**	Baku State is the national flagship; programmes are steadily internationalising but global ranks remain modest. [1]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Very low tuition and living costs; international medical students find it especially affordable.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Safe streets, a clean metro and an orderly seaside boulevard.
Personal growth	**6 / 10**	Cultural life is growing, though student freedoms are more constrained than in Türkiye.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	A Turkic-Persian-European crossroads, but English is limited outside campus.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Strong traditions in oil engineering and medicine.
Independence and flexibility	**7 / 10** was 6	Daily life runs in Azerbaijani or Russian: a real immersion challenge. **Change:** Azerbaijani or Russian needed daily: real practice in unfamiliar situations.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	The economy centres on energy; opportunities outside it are narrower.
Collaboration and community	**6 / 10**	Friendly campuses with growing numbers of international, especially medical, students.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	Degrees serve the region well; wider mobility usually needs further study.

Alexandria, Egypt

Universities: Alexandria University

The Mediterranean's ancient city of learning, still teaching hundreds of thousands.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**6 / 10**	A large, historic public university strongest in medicine, engineering and science, with stretched resources. [1]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Symbolic public fees and seaside living at a fraction of Western costs.
Safety and convenience	**6 / 10**	Friendlier and calmer than Cairo, but still a demanding Egyptian megacity.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	Corniche life, cafés and a storied literary heritage.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	Less international today than in its cosmopolitan past, but deeply cultured.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	The city of the ancient Library: scholarly heritage on every street.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Students quickly become resourceful and self-reliant.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	The regional job market is limited; medicine graduates fare best.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Enormous, warm-hearted student community.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	A respected name in Egypt and the Arab world; many look abroad afterwards.

Tashkent, Uzbekistan

Universities: National University of Uzbekistan (NUUz) · Tashkent Pediatric Medical Institute

Central Asia's historic scholarly capital, reforming and reopening to the world.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**6 / 10**	NUUz is the national flagship; the medical institutes draw growing numbers of international students. [1]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Among the cheapest places in the world to earn a recognised degree.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	Safe, orderly and clean, with a Soviet-era metro.
Personal growth	**7 / 10** was 6	A quieter social scene, enlivened by bazaars, parks and student theatres. **Change:** Daily language immersion builds resilience and character.
Broader horizons	**6 / 10**	Deep Silk Road heritage, but limited everyday English and fewer foreign peers.
Experience and wisdom	**6 / 10**	Strong schools of mathematics, oriental studies and medicine.
Independence and flexibility	**7 / 10** was 6	Uzbek or Russian is needed daily: immersion builds character fast. **Change:** Uzbek or Russian needed daily: real practice in unfamiliar situations.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	A reform-era economy opening new doors in business, IT and medicine.
Collaboration and community	**6 / 10**	Hospitable campuses; the international community is small but growing.
Lifelong opportunity	**6 / 10**	Best for careers in Central Asia or further study abroad.

Rabat, Morocco

Universities: Mohammed V University

A calm Atlantic capital whose flagship university anchors Morocco's ties with Africa and Europe.

Criterion	Score	What it means here
Quality education	**6 / 10**	Mohammed V University is Morocco's flagship, strongest in medicine, law and the sciences, teaching in Arabic and French. [1]
Affordability	**10 / 10**	Near-free public tuition and moderate living costs.
Safety and convenience	**8 / 10**	One of Africa's calmest capitals; compact and walkable.
Personal growth	**8 / 10**	A gentle blend of Andalusian heritage, French influence and modern Moroccan life.
Broader horizons	**8 / 10**	A bridge between Africa and Europe with wide Francophone networks.
Experience and wisdom	**8 / 10**	Roman ruins, medina crafts and a living tradition of scholarship.
Independence and flexibility	**8 / 10**	Friendly and manageable, a soft landing for life abroad; French or Arabic helps.
Career readiness	**6 / 10**	A competitive domestic market; many careers point toward France, Canada or the Gulf.
Collaboration and community	**8 / 10**	Welcoming campuses with students from across West and Central Africa.
Lifelong opportunity	**8 / 10**	Strong lifelong networks across the Francophone world and the African continent.

Sources

[1] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS World University Rankings 2026*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2025.

[2] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS World University Rankings 2027*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2026.

[3] Quacquarelli Symonds. *QS Arab Region University Rankings 2026*. QS Quacquarelli Symonds, 2025.

[4] U.S. News & World Report. *Best Global Universities Rankings, 2026 edition*. U.S. News & World Report, 2026.

Scores reflect typical tuition levels, cost of living and publicly reported safety information as of November 2026, as given in the original report. They are indicative judgements for orientation, not precise measurement.